

A 15-second storyboard

Portrait 9:16, readable with the sound off, the loop understood in five seconds: serve, stack the coins, build.

0–2 s • Hook

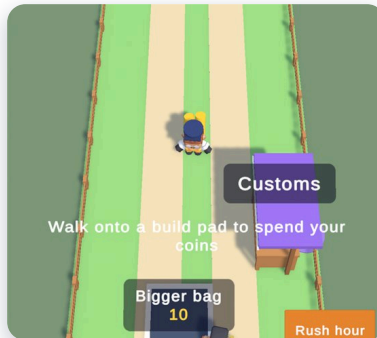


A Grand Liner glides in under a gold envelope and a crowd pours onto the dock.

20 PASSENGERS. 1 HARBOURMASTER.

Sound: Ship bell, crowd murmur

2–5 s • The rule

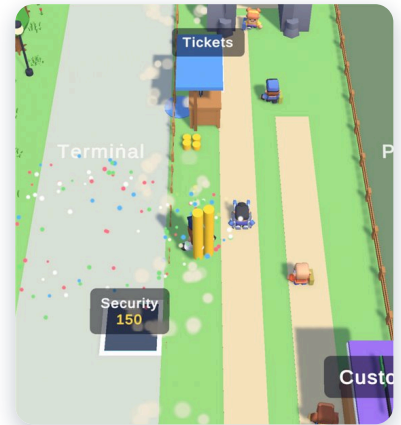


Close on the harbourmaster: a tall stack of coins sways on his back as he runs to a pad.

SERVE. STACK. BUILD.

Sound: Coin clinks, rising in pitch

5–8 s • The payoff



He stands on the Terminal's gold pad: the fence drops, confetti bursts, the zone opens.

OPEN THE TERMINAL!

Sound: Pizzicato jingle, whoosh

8–11 s • Growth



Time-lapse: counters land, clerks nod, stars appear, the queues turn to hearts.

HIRE STAFF. GROW YOUR PORT.

Sound: Music swells, a pop per build

11–13 s • Variety

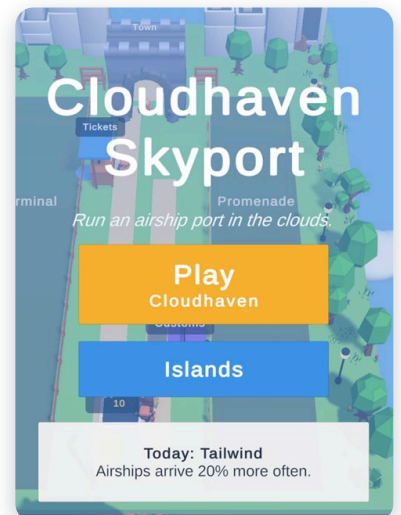


Cut to Galewind: a storm ship under a dark cloud, then Lantern Reach at dusk.

NEW ISLANDS. NEW SKIES.

Sound: Thunder, then lounge music

13–15 s • End card



The logo over the island, a Play button that pulses. Store badges.

PLAY FREE

Sound: Bell and stinger

Why this cut: the genre sells on the stack. A tall pile of coins on a running character is the most recognisable image in arcade idle ads (Mini Mart, Burger Please), and it's our core verb. The hook is a crowd the player will have to handle; the payoff is a zone opening, the moment the island visibly grows. Every frame is real gameplay captured from the build, so the ad promises the first minutes of play.

Three hooks, one decision

Before content, one question: will people install it at a price the game can pay back?

Creative variants

VARIANT	FIRST 2 SECONDS	WHAT IT TESTS
A · The crowd (above)	A Grand Liner unloads 20 travellers onto an empty dock	Pressure and the rescue fantasy
B · The stack	The coin stack grows from 2 to 90 in one continuous run, ASMR clinks	Pure satisfaction, the genre's core audience
C · Fail then fix	Angry faces fill a customs queue; one clerk is hired; the faces turn to hearts	Management and the 'I'd do it better' hook

Test design

SETTING	
Channels	Meta (Facebook, Instagram) and one ad network (AppLovin or Unity Ads), where arcade idle tests usually run
Geos	US for the go / kill decision; a cheaper tier-2 geo (Brazil, Turkey) to iterate creatives first
Build	The Android build behind a store page (or a soft-launch listing), analytics on
Budget	About \$150–250 per variant in the cheap geo, then the winner at about \$500 in the US
Length	3–5 days per round, at least 1,000 impressions per variant before reading CTR
Rounds	Up to three creative rounds before the kill decision

Go / iterate / kill (US, Meta)

Go

- $CPI \leq \$0.35$
- $CTR \geq 3\%$, $IPM \geq 40$ on the network
- $D1 \geq 40\%$ from the test cohort
- Day-0 playtime ≥ 20 minutes

Move to soft launch with the KPI plan.

Iterate

- $CPI \$0.35\text{--}0.70$, or
- good CTR but weak store conversion

Change the hook first (cheapest), then the store page (icon, first screenshot), then the first minute of play.

Kill

- CPI above \$0.70 after three creative rounds, or
- D1 below 30% even with a good CPI

The fantasy isn't landing: try the setting (a ground airport, a space port) before spending on content.

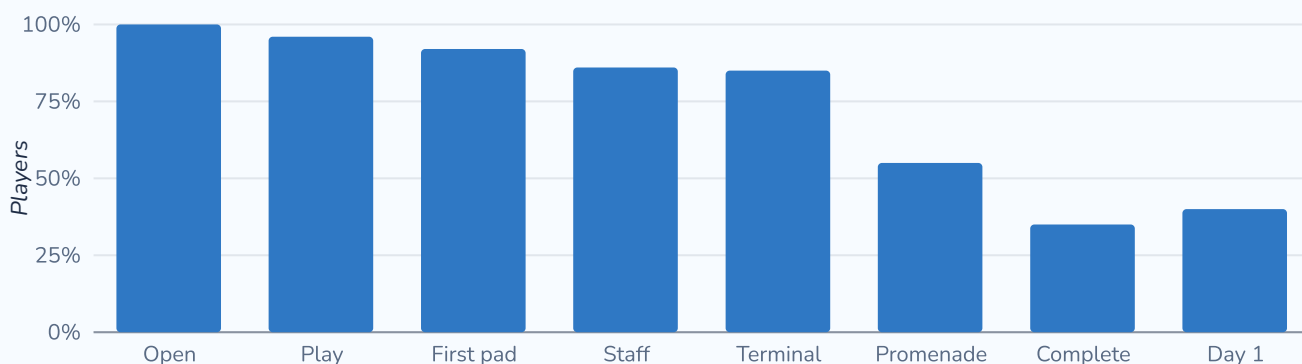
Why the go line is low, and still a stretch: the game shows *only* rewarded ads. With the targets overleaf (D1 40%, D7 12%, D30 4%) a player is active about 4.5 days in the first month; at 2.5 rewarded views a day (\$12 US eCPM) plus 1% buying "remove ads", that is about **\$0.16 by day 30**. Three interstitials a day, shown only on leaving an island, lift it to about \$0.27 (the workbook's Monetisation sheet runs both). So a \$0.35 CPI pays back after day 30 and needs that test in soft launch. Planning assumptions, to replace with a publisher's benchmarks.

What we measure, and what we change

Every KPI maps to an event the game already logs through `IAnalytics` (ten events, written to a local JSON-lines file in this build; a real SDK drops in behind the same interface).

KPI	TARGET	MEASURED BY	IF IT MISSES
D1 retention	40%	<code>app_open</code> on day 1	Onboarding: the first pad, the Terminal at ~4 min
D7 retention	12%	<code>app_open</code> on day 7	The mid-island plateau; offline pull; daily events
D30 retention	4%	<code>app_open</code> on day 30	Content depth: islands, events
Session length	8–12 min	<code>session_end</code>	Too short: nothing to buy; too long: no stopping point
Sessions per day	3+	<code>app_open</code>	The 2-hour offline cap and its reminder
Tutorial done (Terminal open)	85%	<code>zone_opened</code>	The first four minutes
Cloudhaven complete	35%	<code>island_complete</code>	The Promenade wall (bot: 29 min)
Offline double opt-in	40%	<code>offline_claimed</code>	The offer's size or placement
Rewarded views per DAU	2.5	<code>offline_claimed</code> + <code>boost_used</code>	Rush hour's value, timing
Payer conversion	1%	<code>purchase</code>	Remove-ads price; a cosmetic airship pack

First-session funnel (targets)



Read pacing in the wild

`pad_bought` with its minute is the real version of the simulator's pad table. Where players are much slower than the new-player bot, the bot is wrong: retune the prices there and rerun the simulator.

Read the plateau

Minutes 5 to 15 are the longest stretch without growth. If `session_end` clusters there, a cheaper first Terminal clerk is the first lever.